THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

PARIS BRANCH

NEWSLETTER 2015

Chairman's Report

This has been a momentous period for the Paris Branch since the last Newsletter, and sadly not for positive reasons. We have lost three stalwart, iconic members of the Branch - our President d'Honneur, Gyles Longley, CBE, MC; Joan Hicks our tireless Events Organizer; and our leading French member, Bob Maloubier, MBE, who had a brilliant war record, serving alongside the British in the SOE. Bob received this award at the British Embassy when it was presented to him by H.M. The Queen on her state visit to France last year. You will find in this Newsletter three obituaries edited from a Paris Branch vantage point, written, for Bob by his SOE colleague Noreen Riols, for Joan by family friend Janet Warby; and for Gyles by colleague, friend and neighbor -myself. It is the time to give our thanks to God for their rich, long lives both for services to their respective countries and to the RBL Paris Branch. The services of Gyles and Joan to the Paris Branch are legendary, and Madame Maloubier told me shortly after Bob's death that of all the ex-service associations of which Bob was a member, it was his Royal British Legion membership which he valued most. May they all Rest in Peace.

Our everyday Branch activities have been maintained, despite these seismic shocks. We were represented at the D-Day Memorial Ceremony at Bayeux Military Cemetery on 6th June. There we linked up, symbolically laying a Poppy wreath together, with two new French partner associations, firstly the D-Day Overlord Association, and also the 50st Highland Division Spirit Association. Overlord was formed by RBL Paris Branch member Marc Laurenceau, a serving officer in the French Régiment de l'Infanterie de Marine. His association's mission is to provide a service to families visiting military graves in Normandy. Marc, who attended both St Cyr and West Point, has so far concentrated on meeting families of US servicemen who fell in the

Normandy campaign. These families are guided to the relevant cemetery, usually at Omaha Beach, and accompanied where possible by local French school-children and local *anciens combattants*. Overlord have been doing this for two years and now wish to extend this service to Commonwealth families, therefore principally, but not exclusively, to the British and Canadians This approach has appealed to your Committee, and our first discussions with the Commonwealth War Grave Commission have been positive. The activity chimes with our own project to develop our relationship with English-speaking schools in the Ile-de-France (more on this below). It is hoped that, if logistics permit, we would involve British schoolchildren in these visits to accompany British and Canadian families on their visit to a family member's grave. The 51st Highland Division, presided over by a former Adjutant-Chef of Marc's Regiment, Lionel Desmaison, is offering a ceremonial service by attending, upon invitation, both Allied and local French ceremonies, principally in Normandy and Brittany. Dressed in Highland No 1 dress they follow British drill orders. Lionel is a qualified piper and is planning to coach other pipers. This project will take a little time to become operational, but it augurs well for our closer relationship with French associations, and for our schools project. Lionel, his Secretary and Treasurer, have all recently joined the RBL Paris Branch, and we look forward to welcoming them at some of our events, as we do the members of Overlord

Since we last reported Committee member Janet Hadley has proceeded to contact all the known English-speaking schools in Ile-de-France, and an inaugural meeting was held with them in the Clubhouse in May. The meeting may be regarded as a very positive step down the road towards working more closely and in unison with the schools and their history teachers. In a word Janet has been developing the concept which she has fashioned from her own teaching experience at the British Section of the Lycée International, of reacting to the wishes of the school-teachers, involving, where appropriate, research and artistic/writing activities with the children in the age range 10 years to Terminale/Sixth Form, all on the theme of Remembrance. It is being considered whether RBL prizes could be awarded to project winners, culminating in 2018 in an Exhibition in Paris of military artefacts at which these prizes would be presented, where possible involving the candidates giving recitals of their literary work in front of their parents,

and of exhibiting their artwork. If you have visited the Clubhouse recently you will have noticed a first exhibited selection of children's exciting poetry and artwork inspired by our class-room talks in the Primary Section of the Lycée International at Saint-Germain-en-Laye in October last. We judge that this project engaging with both parents and children, is excellent P.R. for the R.B.L.

Also on the home front I can report on another successful Battlefield visit in May, this time to the Ypres Salient. Sadly our usual guide, Colonel Oliver Warman, was not able to lead us, having been under the surgeon's knife only one day before our visit began. You would want me to pass on to him our warm regards and to wish him a speedy, lasting recovery.

I draw your attention to our traditional Ravivage de la Flamme sous l'Arc de Triomphe on 4th August at 6.30 p.m. You will recall that this commemorates the Commonwealth Fallen in both World Wars and in subsequent conflicts. This year it is the turn of the South African Ambassador to rekindle the Fame. Why 4th August ? It was the day in 1914 when the British Empire declared war, one day after the French, on Imperial Germany. As the Foreign Secretary, Earl Grey, famously said that evening, while looking out from his office over St James's Park, "The lights are going out all over Europe". Please *venez nombreux* to support the Springboks.

May I close with a moving anecdote. I was invited by a family living in my native Worcestershire to lay a wreath on 9th May on the grave of a member of their family in Clichy Nord Cemetery. It is the story of one man's war, and is worth telling. The soldier's sister and her husband, an RBL member, wished to commemorate the death of her brother on 9th May 1945. Corporal Albert Thompson of my Regiment, the Worcesters, was captured at Dunkirk in 1940. He was imprisoned for the rest of the war in Germany until his POW camp was liberated. He then found hs way to Paris, where he was offered a flight back with other former POW's to the UK in an RAF plane. In the event the plane turned out to be overloaded and it crashed shortly after take-off, killing all on board. What an irony, to have survived Dunkirk and then after nearly 5 years' captivity, only to be killed the day after VE Day, which was of course the occasion of a great celebration in Paris, as it was in London.

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FOR YOUR DIARY

JULY 2015

Thursday9th **Monthly Lunch** in the Clubhouse at 12.30 for 1 p.m.
Cost: 17€ per head.
Bookings to be made with our new Events Organizer, Edouard Plunkett. You may reach him by e-mail on edouard.plunkett@massoury.fr.
Why not make this an opportunity to invite a friend with a view to having him/her join the RBL in time to come to the next two events below ?

AUGUST 2015

Tuesday 4th **Commonwealth Ravivage de la Flamme** at the Arc de Troimphe. At 6.30 p.m. See Secretary's Screed in this letter, where Janet gives the event details.
The South Aftrican Ambassador rekindles the Flame this year on behalf of the Commonwealth.

SEPTEMBER 2015

Sunday 6th **Pedal to Paris Bicycle Rally.** The riders reach the Arc de Triomphe at around 3.30 p.m. having left Greenwich on the previous Thursday.
It is advisable for spectators to arrive at around 3 p.m., since the organizers cannot guarantee a precise time of arrival. There is lots of emotion in the air as the 200 or so sponsored riders will have bonded after 3 days on the road together. This event is a must attend in the Paris Branch year !! This is a huge fund-raising event for the RBL.Poppy Appeal.

SECRETARY'S SCREED

Dear Members,

As you are aware our friend and colleague, Joan Hicks, died suddenly in May. I am very pleased and relieved to inform you all that member Edouard Plunkett, has offered his services to fill the gap left by Joan. Thank you Edouard for helping us out; we will give you all the help you need whilst you settle into the role of Events Organiser.

August 4th : Please can I draw your attention to the Annual Ceremony of Rekindling the Flame at the Arc de Triomphe on Tuesday 4th August. The ceremony starts promptly at 18h30. Anyone wishing to march behind the Colour Party and Standards should be at the top of the Champs Elysées no later than 18h00 ready to be marched off by our Parade Marshal and the Guardian de la Flamme. If you cannot or do not wish to march behind our Colours then please proceed to the Arc de Triomphe by 18h00 to be in place near the Flamme at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier. The V.I.P. Who will rekindle the Flame this year will be from the Embassy of the Republic of South Africa. After the ceremony we hold a Vin d'Honneur at the Legion, all welcome to come back and raise a glass or two. If you would like to come back to the Legion, could I ask you to complete the slip below and send it to me at the Legion address; this is for catering purposes.

We hope to see as many of you at the Arc as possible.

Best wishes to you all

Janet Warby
Hon. Secretary

4th AUGUST REPLY SLIP

I _____ would like to attend the ceremony at the Arc de Triomphe and would also like to attend the Vin d'Honneur at the Legion afterwards.

I would like to bring _____ person(s) with me.

Signed _____ Dated_____

CRABBIES GRAND NATIONAL 2015

RESULTS

Place	Name of Horse	Drawn By	Odds
1st	Many Clouds	Max Genock	25-1
2nd	Saint Are	David Bean	25-1
3rd	Monbeg Dude	Lindy Spencer-Bernard	40-1
4th	Alvarado	Midge Hopkin	20-1
5th	Shutthefrontdoor	Tony Bennett	6-1 fav
6th	Royale Knight	Diana Neill	25-1
7th	Tranquil Sea	P. Gautier-Lynham	33-1
8th	Cause of Causes	Carmen Thourot	14-1
9th	Soll	Graham Scott	9-1
10th	Chance du Roy	P. Huggins	40-1
11th	Mon Parrain	Mariette Peron	33-1
12th	Pineau de Re	Charles Ignatovitch	25-1
13th	Owega Star	N. Fleury	50-1
14th	Spring Heeled	Jane c/o Wolstenholme	25-1
15th	Oscar Time	J. Quinlan	20-1
16th	First Lieutenant	Roger Warby	14-1
17th	Rocky Creek	G. Corrigan	8-1
18th	Night in Milan	Odile Ignatovitch	20-1
19th	Dolatulo	Stuart Thorn	66-1

The other horses, which either fell, unseated their riders or were pulled up are as follows:

Fence 1: Ely Brown (fell) Gas Line Boy (fell) Al Co (unseated). Fence 3 : Rubi Light (unseated) Fence 4: Corrin Wood (pulled up), Fence 5 : Unioniste (fell), Fence 6 : River Choice (fell), Fence 8 Balthazar King (fell), Ballycasey (unseated), Fence 19 : Court by Surprise (pulled up), Fence 25 : Across the Bay (pulled up) Super Duty (pulled up), Lord Windermere (pulled up), Fence 26 : The Rainbow Hunter (fell), The Druids Nephew (fell), Fence 27 : Rebel Rebellion (pulled up), Fence 28 Portrait King (fell), Fence 29 : Godsmejudge (pulled up), Wyck Hill (pulled up) Bob Ford (pulled up).

One horse, Carlito Brigante, was withdrawn from the race after the 10 am declaration stage on 10th April which was too late for a reserve horse to be included.

We would like to congratulate the winner and runners up and to thank all those who took part in the draw.



Oliver Gyles Longley CBE, MC

1918-2015

Much has been written and said about Gyles' life, in his autobiography, at his Funeral and in his Obituary in "The Daily Telegraph" last week. These sources have mostly concentrated on his C.V. and his achievements. I thought for the record it would be an opportunity to put pen to paper on Gyles, the man behind the achievements.

Above is a wonderful photograph of Gyles as we shall long remember him. Here he is, at one with the world , smiling and proudly sporting his medals just as we had come out of Notre Dame de Paris Cathedral on 11th November last year.

Writing as I am in an RBL Newsletter I nevertheless cannot avoid referring to his war career. 71 years ago he was appointed Lt. Colonel of his Reconnaissance Regiment at the tender age of 25. What was the role of a Reconnaissance Regiment ? Recruited from Infantry regiments the troops were quite simply required to go forward in advance of the main body of Infantry and Armour to probe the ground ahead, identifying where the enemy was situated, but not engaging with them unless obliged to do so (which occurred frequently however). In a word it was an extremely dangerous mission, and was not the place for the faint-hearted. Gyles showed extreme bravery and demonstrated his most compelling quality, that of intuitive leadership. This is a quality which the Army quickly identifies, and Gyles delivered the goods, winning his M.C. in an unpredicted, but always likely engagement with the enemy in the Italian campaign. Gyles recalls the subsequent peace-time annual reunions between the Eighth Army and the Afrika Korps. He discovered that there was a surprisingly good atmosphere on such occasions. The Desert War had been largely fought by soldiers with a professional attitude, who had a respect for each other, and it had been conducted on chivalrous principles. There was not an ounce of spite in Gyles.

A leader like any sports captain intuitively knows his men, their strengths and weaknesses. In the RBL I witnessed this with Gyles. After a particularly heated RBL Branch Committee meeting over 10 years ago, which led ultimately to the request to a Branch officer to resign because of disloyal, unprofessional behaviour, Gyles who had listened quietly to the debate, sidled up to me at the bar after the meeting and whispered "That was a difficult situation for you. Let me give you a lift home, and we can talk about it". He was spot on. I needed that moral support at that particular moment in time.

In another register I recall Gyles' ready financial generosity. A recent example that came to my attention was in the Autumn of 2014, when I had written to him to report how a Branch member had bumped into an ex-Spitfire pilot living in Paris. Gyles immediately expressed interest, saying that he didn't know that there were <u>any</u> Spitfire survivors wandering around Paris. "Let me invite them all to a Dinner at the Cercle Inter-allié at my expense". I re-read that correspondence last week, and indeed in the context the invitation was not limited to Spitfire pilots, but was to invite all World War Two survivors living in Ile de France. "We'll have a lot to talk about, I'm sure", he added. That project was denied him through lack of time, as shortly

afterwards he fell ill. Such was his generosity, both financially and in spirit too. The fellowship of *frères d'armes*.

For some time now I have had a couple of quotations running around in my mind when reflecting on Gyles. Born as he was not 100 miles from Canterbury he merits the Chaucer quotation that he was a "verray parfit, gentil knight". Then more reflectively up came from the depths of one's memory: Hamlet's recollection of his murdered father "We shall not look upon his like again". Gyles was like all of us a child of his time, fashioned by the war, and able to take those qualities discovered by the Army into a successful business career afterwards. As he commented once on his own management style "I never used to order anyone to do something, I simply chose the right people and they followed me. Never had any staff problems"

Finally mention must be made of Gyles's faith. Not as an afterthought, because it was of course a mainstay of his life. In war-time he had seen enough horror to last a life-time, but as Canon Alyson Lamb pointed out at his funeral Gyles revealed to her during her last hospital visit to see him that he had felt the presence of the Holy Spirit at his bed-side in hospital, so that he died in the faith, as he had lived in it. At the tender age of 88 he had decided to attend the Alpha course at St Michael's, which was in an attempt to probe and test his faith once more. In church he was as much at ease talking to the young people as he was talking to the clergy. He was a people person. He knew the names of every shop-keeper here in Le Vésinet, and for him all people were interesting, irrespective of rank. Perhaps he was sent among us to show us how life should be lived. He was for many of us the elder brother we never had, or the grandfather we had never known. We were comfortable talking to him about our troubles, and he was a good listener. In a word he has marked the life of everyone he met. So in conclusion here's an idea by which to remember him: In any difficult situation in which we may find ourselves in the future can we stop and ask ourselves: "What would Gyles recommend that I do in this situation ?".

Tribute should here be paid to two Legion members, both of them Gyles' executors, Roy Mitchell and David Blanchard, who gave him professional support throughout his preparations for leaving this life. Also and particularly to Jan Mitchell who was tireless in her pastoral and administrative care of Gyles in the last months of his life.

R.I.P.



JOAN MARGARET HICKS

I had known Joan since we both joined the Royal British Legion, Paris Branch, Committee in 1992/3. Joan took on the role of Social Secretary and I became Assistant Secretary and Standard Bearer.

Joan was the youngest of four children born to an English father and French mother. By her own admission, Joan says she was a bit of a 'tomboy' because she had three brothers, George, John (Jack) and Robert (Bob). She was born in Garche on St. Georges Day, 1927. Although brought up in France, Joan never lost her English roots, indeed when H.M. The Queen and HRH The Duke of Edinburgh visited Paris last June, Joan was at the Arc de Triomphe when the Officials there told her that she and her friends would have to leave. Upon hearing this, Joan turned to them and said "This is our Queen and we are staying"! Joan often talked about her visits to family in Kent, when I asked where, she said Whitstable and Canterbury. This was a coincidence as our last family home was in Whitstable and our children went to school in Canterbury. I told Joan once about a road between Whitstable and Canterbury called Hicks Forstal, she looked at me and with a twinkle in her eye and smiling said "I know it well".

Joan's family were members of the Standard Athletic Club and her father and brothers would play in the Cricket Team. One day they were short of a scorer so, her father said "Joan, you can be scorer,

you have done it before". Joan agreed and all was going well until there was no score to put down. Joan said her mind went blank, what was it she was supposed to say? Suddenly she remembered it had to do with a young girl and shouted out "Virgin Over". Joan says it all went very quiet, everyone looking at her and then batsmen, bowler and fielders crying with laughter. It took a long time before the team would let her forget this. Of course she should have said "Maiden Over"!

When the Second World War broke out, Joan's father tried to get his family out of France only to be eventually turned back to Garche/Vaucresson where they had been living. Once back in the Paris area her father and brothers were taken to a camp at St. Denis, Joan and her mother were taken to Maisons-Laffitte, where they were pushed onto trains and taken to an internment camp in Besançon in the East of France. After many months, children under the age of 16, their mothers and elderly persons over the age of 65 were sent back home. The children were informed that once they turned 16 they would be returned to the camp. Joan was 13 when she was first taken to the camp. When she turned 16 the same German Sergeant who had taken them to Besançon came for Joan and her mother and took them to the Vittel camp until liberation by General Leclerc's army in September 1944. Her stories and that of her eldest brother, George, can be read in the book 'Our Say, Not Hearsay', which was published last year for the RBL Paris Branch. I asked Joan once what it was like in the camps. She replied "Not bad, but not good, we had lost our liberty".

Joan was more than a good friend, she was part of our family. At one of the Annual Dinner/Dances the RBL held and which Joan organised for us, our family attended. Our son, Grahame, was about 15/16, when the dancing started only Joan and Grahame were left at the table. So being the perfect gentleman, Grahame asked Joan if she would like to dance but warned her that he could not waltz. "Don't worry chum, I'll teach you" said Joan. That was the beginning of a relationship whereby Grahame asked Joan if she would be his Godmother – we had lost touch with his original Godmother – Joan immediately agreed and always made a point of seeing Grahame when he came home from University or coming home with his wife and little boy for Christmas and other family holidays. Joan took her duites as Godmother very seriously.

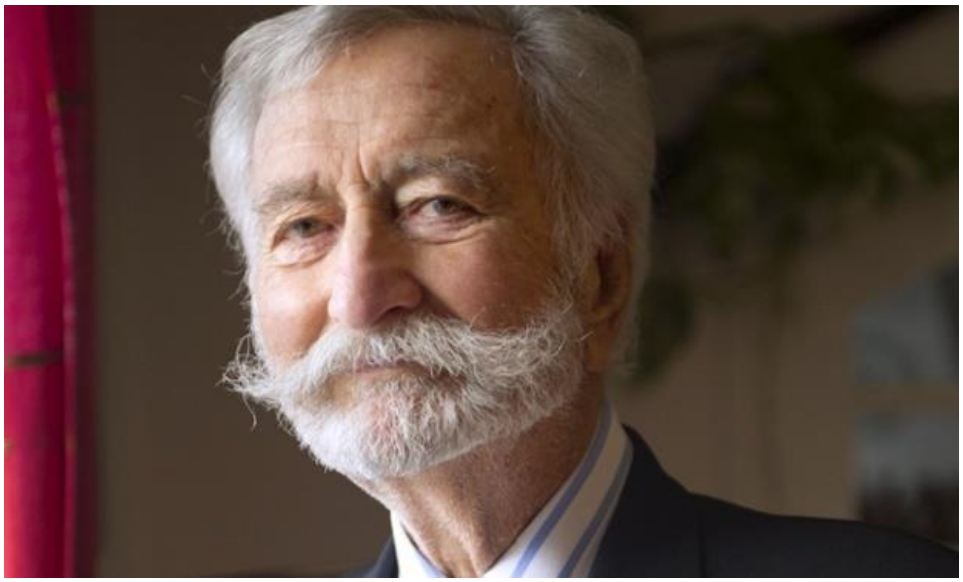
Whenever she could, Joan loved nothing more than to end an event at the Legion with a sing-song. She loved the old songs from the war years. I have fond memories of her getting the song sheets out and the tape recorder going. She would motivate the most miserable person to sing and be jolly.

Whatever she did, whether it be carrying the Standard with me at a ceremony, organising lunches, Christmas parties or singing in the Choir in Feucherolles she did with a smile. She never let much get her down even when she was diagnosed with cancer and had to have two operations and chemotherapy, a back operation and trying to keep her diabetes under control, she took it all in her stride.

And so my dear friend, as Vera Lynn, one of your favourite singers, sang in the war, We'll Meet Again, Don't Know Where, Don't Know When, But I Know We'll Meet Again Some Sunny Day.

I'll miss our chats and lunches but I have lots of fond memories of a dear friend, Sleep Well.

Janet Warby
Hon. Secretary



Bob Maloubier

Could you write a few words about Bob, I was asked. You knew him so well.

A few words? About Bob?
Impossible!

Bob could fill an entire encyclopedia.

He was probably the last of the swashbuckling buccaneers. James Bond, the three musketeers and Starwars rolled into one. With his passing a whole era has gone, taking a huge slice of my life with it.

We had come to believe that Bob was immortal. How many times in the past few years have the doctors shaken their heads and said he couldn't last more than a few days. The bullets he had received while escaping from the Gestapo, some of which were still lodged in his body, had finally triumphed. But he always surprised them, and bounced back. Perhaps it was the amount of champagne he consumed, the only alcoholic drink he ever touched which kept him "bubbling". I thought he would surprise the doctors again this last time, so it was a terrible shock when God decided otherwise. As someone remarked at his funeral "a light has gone out of the world".

Urged by his father who had worked with the British during the First World War, to answer General de Gaulle's call to all Frenchmen to join him in London to continue the fight, in June 1940 at the age of seventeen Bob set off from their holiday home in Britanny to cycle to Bordeaux and then on to St. Jean de Luz in an attempt to board a boat for England. He finally made it.... in 1943, after crossing the Pyrenees on foot and passing through North Africa where he was recruited by SOE and flown to London. From then on until he reached the age of 92 his life was non-stop excitement, adventure and devotion to duty.

Trained as an SOE agent Bob was parachuted twice into occupied France and once into Laos there to fight in the jungle against the Japanese. His exploits were legendary. If asked what he had done during the war he always replied, with his characteristic shrug: "I was just a saboteur". Just a saboteur! But what a saboteur. One who was responsible for the destruction of a German warship in Rouen and after D-Day, alone blew up six bridges in one night to prevent the German army advance. And the following morning blew up a couple more. Who trained hundreds of resistants, going from group to group showing them how to make dynamite, use hand grenades, prepare bombs and booby traps, handle and dismantle bren and sten guns. He volunteered for the Special Boat Service and later established the French SBS. When the war in Europe ended he joined Force 136, the SOE unit in the Far East and was parachuted into Laos.

One might think of Bob as a man who did not know the meaning of fear. I once asked him whether there was a moment during the war when he had been very afraid. He gave me a strange look and said quietly: "I was afraid all the time. And when I was in front of the

Gestapo I literally trembled." Yet he carried out 3 missions parachuting behind the lines into enemy territory.

Thanks to Bob I understood that brave men are always afraid . That courage is not the absence of fear but the ability, the guts if you like, to face what you fear. Like so many other agents, Bob faced his fear.... And left.

After the war he was recruited by the DSGT, the French MI6 And I wouldn't be surprised if he wasn't still working for them when he died. It was the Head of the DSGT who gave a splendid tribute to Bob at his funeral in the Invalides where he was accorded full military honours with eight stalwart parachutists carrying his flag draped coffin and a ninth following bearing a cushion on which were his many medals, both French and English, including the D.S.O

Bob's life was one long adventure., as described in the many successful books he wrote. He said in one that I tried to seduce him at Beaulieu in 1943. I don't know whether it was a joke on his part or whether he believed it, because I wasn't at Beaulieu in 1943! His last book on Claude Dansey who retired as head of MI6 as Sir Claude, was published at the beginning of April, only a few days before he died.

I am very moved when I remember that one of his last "public appearances" was at the ceremony in October at which I was awarded the Legion of Honour, France's highest decoration. He had arrived with a folding wheelchair in the boot of the car. But he left it there, insisting on walking unaided into our eldest son's house where the ceremony was held and standing beside me leaning on his stick

throughout the whole proceedings. During the reception which followed one might have wondered who had received the honour since it was Bob everyone was flocking around. He had a wonderful time.

His swan song A last curtain call.

There have been so many documentaries made, so many eulogies written and pronounced about Bob by high-ranking friends both military and civilian, especially since his death, that everyone must now be aware of his amazing exploits. At his funeral the cathedral at the Invalides was crammed with people, estimated at over seven hundred, wanting to pay their respects and say goodbye so I don't feel there is anything else left for me to say. Except perhaps to quote what I wrote in the book of Condoléances.

Au revoir, vieux camarade .....à bientôt.

No. of words: 955